

Sentience

As a self-proclaimed RPG nut, and someone who enjoys games for their story just as much as their gameplay, I've come across several NPCs who are very dear to me. I mean I literally think of them fondly as companions who've been with me through thick and thin and were by my side as I took on my many epic quests to save the world (or the Galaxy). We've cracked jokes together, we've shared meals together and we've even wept for the loss of loved NPCs together. But despite all that, I always knew they weren't real.

At the end of the day, no matter how many times I replayed the game, I always knew exactly what they were going to say and how they were going to behave. And while developers have done a fantastic job of bringing some of the NPCs "to life", everyone knows they aren't truly sentient. Which is where this issue's cover story comes in. The Ultimate NPC. It's quite in line with the overall theme of this month's issue, don't you think?

As a gamer when you think of AI, you're thinking in-game AI; NPCs. So, what does AI think the ultimate in-game AI should be like? It's certainly an interesting experiment, and the results, which you will soon read, are not too far from what I would personally want to see from NPCs in the future.

Imagine if NPCs were able to think for themselves, and make decisions in real-time based on what they're experiencing. This would go a long way in making RPGs a lot more replayable. Imagine an RPG being like a roguelike, where no two runs are the same because the AI might

behave differently based on different circumstances. Of course this would apply to the enemies as well, which would be a lot smarter, and maybe even outsmart you in combat!

The majority of this month's SKOAR! Issue has been done the same way, using AI, and you could in a way think of this as an experiment in the capabilities of AI to assist with game development, world building, and creating interesting lore. However, I don't personally believe that AI will be able to top human creativity, at least not yet. But they could certainly help create a foundation for future game projects.

One of the game reviews in this month's issue is also written by AI. Of course, the review in question is of a game that we asked AI to design. Once again, an interesting experiment, with interesting results, which you will soon see.

Overall, we're at an interesting juncture where the future of not just the gaming industry, but the world in general could change drastically. Whether this will be a good thing or a bad thing is still up in the air, but just the thought of what this could result in for the future of games is very interesting. *



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